

[Lesson 25](#): Priesthood: “The Power of Godliness” (See L25 [Class Member Study Guide](#))

Purpose: To help us gain a greater understanding of the priesthood and seek the blessings that come from using it righteously.

1. Order in the restoration of the priesthood and its offices

“The Aaronic Priesthood and the Melchizedek Priesthood were restored to the earth in 1829 (see lesson 8). Following the organization of the Church in 1830, the Lord gradually revealed priesthood offices, quorums, and councils as needed to provide leadership for the growth of the Church. The following time line summarizes this restoration.” (*Lesson Manual*)

Aaronic Priesthood: 15 May 1829 > Melchizedek Priesthood: May or June 1829 > Apostles, elders, priests, teachers, and deacons: April 1830 > Bishop: 4 February 1831 > High Priests: June 1831 > First Presidency: 1832-33 > Patriarch: 18 December 1833 > High council: 17 February 1834 > Quorum of the Twelve Apostles: 1835 > Seventies: 1835 > First Quorum of the Seventy: 1835

In “our day the Lord continues to give revelations about the organization and responsibilities of the priesthood to guide the growth of the Church. One example of this is the calling of Area Authority Seventies and the accompanying organization of the Third, Fourth, and Fifth Quorums of the Seventy in 1997 (see lesson 42, pages 247-48).” (*LM*)

2. The oath and covenant of the priesthood

In “addition to revelations about priesthood offices and government, the Lord revealed principles about receiving and exercising the priesthood. For example, He revealed the oath and covenant of the priesthood, which is found in D&C 84:33-44. These verses outline (1) the covenants a man makes with the Lord when he receives the Melchizedek Priesthood and (2) the covenants the Lord makes with faithful Melchizedek Priesthood holders.” (*Lesson Manual*)

†1. Elder Carlos E. Asay †2. Joseph Fielding Smith

• D&C 84:33, 36, 39-44. †3. Priesthood holders covenant to:

• D&C 107:99; Jacob 1:17-19. What does it mean to magnify a calling? †4. President Gordon B. Hinckley How have you been blessed by someone who magnified his or her calling?

†5. Elder Neal A. Maxwell—How can we balance our work, our families, and our callings? What does it mean to receive the Lord’s servants?

†6. The Lord Covenants to:

What are the blessings and responsibilities of the seed of Abraham?

How can the Lord’s promise of all that He has, help us in times of adversity and in times of plenty?

3. Principles for using the priesthood

• D&C 121:34-46. In “these verses the Lord reveals principles for using the priesthood. He also reveals promises to those who use it righteously. In addition to their application to priesthood holders, these principles apply generally to all human relationships.” (*Lesson Manual*)

• D&C 121:34-40. What prevents men from exercising their priesthood with power? †7. Sheri L. Dew

What are ways we care too much for “the things of this world” and “aspire to the honors of men”?

What are some examples of attempting to cover our sins, or gratifying our pride or vain ambition?

What are some ways we may exercise unrighteous “control or dominion or compulsion” on the souls of men?

†8. Elder Vaughn J. Featherstone †9. Ted L. Gibbons †10. Ted L. Gibbons #2

†11. Ted L. Gibbons #3 †12. Elder M. Russell Ballard

How can we overcome these tendencies of our natural disposition?

• D&C 121:41-42. These revealed principles of influence can help us overcome our natural disposition.

• D&C 43-44. “*Betimes* means ‘promptly’ or ‘soon.’ In the context of this passage, *with sharpness* means ‘clearly’ or ‘precisely,’ *not* ‘severely’ or ‘roughly.’” (*Lesson Manual*; emphasis added)

How do the consequences of disciplining with love differ from the consequences of disciplining with anger?

• D&C 121:45-46. What does it mean to “let virtue garnish thy thoughts unceasingly”?

How can we keep evil or unvirtuous thoughts out of our minds? (See [D&C 27:15-18](#).)

How can we more actively fill our minds with virtuous thoughts?

What does the Lord promise if we are “full of charity” and “let virtue garnish [our] thoughts unceasingly”?

What does it mean to be confident in the presence of God? †13. Elder Gordon B. Hinckley

Next Week: L26: “Go Ye into All the World, and Preach My Gospel”; See L26 [Class Member Study Guide](#).
(You can download a free LDS Institute manual at: [Doctrine and Covenants Manual: Religion 324 and 325](#).) † •

†1. **Elder Carlos E. Asay:** “Of all the holy agreements pertaining to the gospel of Jesus Christ, few, if any, would transcend in importance the oath and covenant of the priesthood. It is certainly one of the most sacred agreements, for it involves the sharing of heavenly powers and man’s upward reaching toward eternal goals. **None of us can afford to be ignorant of the terms of this contract. To do so might cause us to miss the mark in our performance of duty and result in the forfeiture of promised blessings.**”

“A gospel covenant is a holy contract. ‘God in his good pleasure fixes the terms, which man accepts.’ (Bible Dictionary, LDS ed., s.v. ‘covenant’.) ([“The Oath and Covenant of the Priesthood,” Ensign](#), Nov. 1985, 43).

†2. **Joseph Fielding Smith:** The “blessings of the priesthood are not confined to men alone. **These blessings are also poured out ... upon all the faithful women of the Church.... The Lord offers to his daughters every spiritual gift and blessing that can be obtained by his sons, for neither is the man without the woman, nor the woman without the man in the Lord**” (in Conference Report, [Apr. 1970, 59](#); or *Improvement Era*, June 1970, 66; see also [Alma 32:23](#)).”

†3. **Priesthood holders covenant to:**

- a. Be faithful in obtaining the Aaronic Priesthood and the Melchizedek Priesthood (verse 33).
- b. Magnify their callings (verse 33).
- c. Receive the Lord’s servants (verse 36).
- d. Give diligent heed to the words of eternal life (verses 43-44).

†4. **President Gordon B. Hinckley:** “We magnify our priesthood and enlarge our calling when we serve with diligence and enthusiasm in those responsibilities to which we are called by proper authority.... We magnify our calling, we enlarge the potential of our priesthood when we reach out to those in distress and give strength to those who falter.... We magnify our calling when we walk with honesty and integrity” ([“Magnify Your Calling,” Ensign](#), May 1989, 48-49).

†5. **Elder Neal A. Maxwell:** “Sometimes, unintentionally, even certain extracurricular Church activities, insensitively administered can hamper family life. Instructively, after the resurrected Jesus taught the Nephites, He said, ‘Go ye unto your homes, and ponder upon the things which I have said,’ and pray and prepare ‘for the morrow’ (3 Nephi 17:3). Jesus did not say go to your civic clubs, town meetings, or even stake centers!” ([“Take Especial Care of Your Family,” Ensign](#), May 1994, 89).

†6. **The Lord Covenants to:**

- a. Sanctify us by the Spirit (verse 33).
- b. Renew our bodies (verse 33).
- c. Give us the blessings promised to Abraham and his posterity (verse 34).
- d. Make us His elect, or chosen (verse 34).
- e. Give us all that the Father has (verse 38).
- f. Give His angels charge over us (verse 42).

†7. **Sheri L. Dew:** “**The adversary is delighted when we act like sightseers**, meaning those who are hearers rather than doers of the word (see James 1:22), **or shoppers**, meaning those preoccupied with the vain things of this world that suffocate our spirits. Satan baits us with perishable pleasures and preoccupations—our bank accounts, our wardrobes, even our waistlines—for he knows that where our treasure is, there will our hearts be also (see Matt. 6:21). Unfortunately, it is easy to let the blinding glare of the adversary’s enticements distract us from the light of Christ” ([“We Are Women of God,” Ensign](#), Nov. 1999, 97).

†8. **Elder Vaughn J. Featherstone:** “Seeking to walk in the Lord’s footsteps recently brought me in contact with a young man and his father. The young man and a friend were up hiking in the lower foothills near Cody, Wyoming. The friend jumped across a high-power line that was down, but the young man got tangled in it and was **electrocuted**. The friend turned and ran all the way back down to where the father lived—and it wasn’t a short distance—and **told the father that his son** had been electrocuted and that he **was dead**. The father, who was not a young man, ran all the way back up, taking about fifteen minutes. When he got up to where the boy was lying across the wires, he somehow removed the boy from the wires with a board or a large branch. Then he picked his son up in his arms and held him, saying, **‘In the name of Jesus Christ and by the power and authority of the holy Melchizedek Priesthood, I command you to live.’** **The dead boy opened up his eyes in his father’s arms** and was taken to the University of Utah Medical Center, where he recovered” ([“Where Following Him Can Lead Us,” Ensign](#), Feb. 1981, 8).

Recommended Reading:

1. Elder Carlos E. Asay, [“The Oath and Covenant of the Priesthood,” Ensign](#), Nov. 1985, 43.
2. President Gordon B. Hinckley, [“Magnify Your Calling,” Ensign](#), May 1989, 48.
3. [Elder Gordon B. Hinckley](#), Conference Report on chastity, Apr. 1970, 63.

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Further Enrichment Resources:

†9. **Ted L. Gibbons** commented on Elder Featherstone's story above: "The father of this boy could not have done the thing he did if his life was awash in unrighteousness. If he had spent secret hours with the pornography on the Internet or with vulgar, violent videos; if immoral thoughts and actions had played constantly or even frequently on the stage of his mind, if he had been abusive to his wife or children or dishonest in his business dealings, there would have been no power and no healing." (See D&C 121:37-39.) (Ted L. Gibbons, [D&C Lesson #25](#), Priesthood: "The Power of Godliness")

†10. **Ted L. Gibbons #2**: "We do not have many dictators in our Church organizations. I am convinced that the greatest application of these verses are to be found in the home. It is there that some give wholesale devotion to the practice of unrighteous dominion. *You will do it my way, because I say you will. I am bigger and smarter and I am not wrong and I am in charge here and you better not forget it or I'll ground you till you are 34 years old!*" (Ted L. Gibbons, [D&C Lesson #25](#), Priesthood: "The Power of Godliness")

†11. **Ted L. Gibbons #3**: "There are words in D&C 121:43 that might be misunderstood. For example, the word 'betimes' does not mean 'once in a while' but 'quickly, promptly, or in good season.' Then when the Lord speaks of 'reproving betimes' he means reproving at the very time it is necessary. We are instructed to offer such reproof with 'sharpness.' In the context of this verse and others, the word clearly means 'with precision or clarity,' not with anger and volume...

"There is one more warning about this matter of 'reproving betimes with sharpness.' We are only permitted to do it when we have a revelation—'when moved upon by the Holy Ghost....'" (Ted L. Gibbons, [D&C Lesson #25](#), Priesthood: "The Power of Godliness")

†12. **Elder M. Russell Ballard**: "Those who hold the priesthood must never forget that they have no right to wield priesthood authority like a club over the heads of others in the family or in Church callings.... Any man who ... seeks to use the priesthood in any degree of unrighteousness in the Church or in the home simply does not understand the nature of his authority. Priesthood is for service, not servitude; compassion, not compulsion; caring, not control" ("[Strength in Counsel](#)," *Ensign*, Nov. 1993, 78).

†13. **Elder Gordon B. Hinckley**: "It has been my privilege on various occasions to converse with Presidents of the United States and important men in other governments. At the close of each such occasion I have reflected on the rewarding experience of standing with confidence in the presence of an acknowledged leader. And then I have thought, what a wonderful thing, what a marvelous thing it would be to stand with confidence—unafraid and unashamed and unembarrassed—in the presence of God. This is the promise held out to every virtuous man and woman" (in Conference Report, [Oct. 1970, 66](#); or *Improvement Era*, Dec. 1970, 73).

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